Low-Cost Ocean Instrumentation Workshop

Woods Hole Oceanographic Institution

October 19–22, 2026

Draft agenda — October 1, 2026

Location	WHOI DeepTech Facility, Woods Hole, Massachusetts
Hands-on Sessions	October 23 and October 26–28 (optional)
Supported by	Schmidt Sciences and the U.S. Office of Naval Research

Workshop Objectives

Affordable, scalable ocean observing systems have the potential to substantially expand observations of the coastal and open ocean by enabling measurements at spatial and temporal scales that are difficult to achieve using traditional research-grade instrumentation. This workshop brings together researchers, engineers, and technologists to exchange technical knowledge, demonstrate emerging technologies, discuss common engineering challenges, and develop collaborations that advance reliable, low-cost ocean observing systems.

Specific objectives:

- Review recent advances in low-cost oceanographic and marine environmental instrumentation.
- Identify scientific and operational observing needs that can be addressed by affordable sensor technologies.
- Share best practices in sensor design, fabrication, calibration, deployment, and long-term operation.
- Foster collaborations among universities, government laboratories, industry, and nonprofit organizations.
- Develop recommendations and priorities for future technology development and collaborative projects.

Program

Talks are 15 minutes plus 5 minutes for questions.

Monday, October 19	
08:00–09:00	*Registration and breakfast*
09:00–09:20	Welcome and workshop objectives — Tom Farrar (WHOI) Remarks — Emily Shroyer (ONR) *[TBC]*
09:20–10:30	Jessica Sandoval (AquaVela) — Accessible Ocean Technology (AOT) for cost-effective, community-driven ocean observing Andrew Thaler (Oceanography for Everyone) — OpenCTD: a low-cost, open-source CTD for ocean research Kyla Drushka (UW-APL) — Backyard Buoys
10:30–11:00	*Coffee break*
11:00–12:00	Kingsley Kojo Darko (University of Ghana) — Low-cost surface drifters for investigating microplastic transport and dispersion in the Gulf of Guinea Yixuan Song (URI) — Title TBD Speaker TBD (remote) — Title TBD Discussion
12:00–13:00	*Lunch*
13:00–14:30	Christopher Piecuch (WHOI) — Observing needs for coastal flooding and sea level Drew Lucas (Scripps) — Waves and tides from a low-cost RTK GNSS buoy Victor Adutwum (KNUST) — A low-cost multi-sensor coastal monitoring system for real-time mean sea level assessment: a Keta coast case study Discussion
14:30–15:00	*Coffee break*
15:00–16:30	Brennan Phillips (URI) — 3D-printed pressure housings and fiber-optic microtethers for low-cost deep-sea exploration Levi Gorrell (WHOI) — Design considerations for a low-cost water-level sensor Jonathan Pfeifer (WHOI) — Open-source sensor engineering and the pHrog low-cost pH sensor Speaker TBD — Waterproof enclosures and performance/cost tradeoffs *[TBC]* Discussion

16:30–17:30	**Lightning talks (5 minutes each)** Nick Lowell (Lowell Instruments) — From basement to ocean: building practical, affordable instruments Moise Busogi (CMU-Africa), Ahmed Aslam Waheed (Maldives National University), Rupak Loodh (BORI), Akyana Britwum (KNUST), Michael Edem Donkor (KNUST) *[TBC]* Open to all participants
Tuesday, October 20	
09:00–10:30	Alex Kinsella (WHOI) — Developing a full-sky thermal camera to advance cloud remote sensing at sea Amina Schartup (Scripps) — A field-deployable method for measuring picomolar mercury levels in natural waters Speaker TBD (remote) — Title TBD Discussion
10:30–11:00	*Coffee break*
11:00–12:30	Melissa Omand (URI) — Title TBD Onset Computer (HOBO) — Title TBD *[TBC]* Blue Robotics — Title TBD *[TBC]* Speaker TBD (remote) — Title TBD Discussion
12:30–13:30	*Lunch*
13:30–15:00	**Panel: Robust low-cost marine systems**
15:00–15:30	*Coffee break*
15:30–17:00	**Demonstrations** Canoe trackers, OMI drifters, uROAM, Snocams, and MINIONs — Melissa Omand (URI) pHrog pH sensor — Jonathan Pfeifer (WHOI) Participants are welcome to bring instruments to demonstrate
Wednesday, October 21	
09:00–10:30	Shah Selbe (FieldKit) — FieldKit Underwater: development and manufacturing of a low-cost sonde for water-chemistry measurement Evan Heberlein (Cornell) — Water velocity measurements with optical and infrared cameras (tentative) Speaker TBD (remote) — Title TBD Discussion
10:30–11:00	*Coffee break*
11:00–12:30	**Open discussion**
12:30–13:30	*Lunch*
13:30–15:00	**DeepTech demonstrations and facility tours** Includes a tour of the WHOI Rigging Shop led by Chris Ross *[time TBC]*
15:00–15:30	*Coffee break*
15:30–17:00	**Breakout discussions**
Thursday, October 22	
09:00–10:30	**Breakout reports**
10:30–10:45	*Coffee break*
10:45–11:45	**Collaborative opportunities and workshop roadmap**
11:45–12:30	**Workshop report planning and closing remarks**
12:30	*Lunch and adjourn*
Friday, October 23 and Monday–Wednesday, October 26–28 (optional)	
All day	**Hands-on development sessions — WHOI DeepTech facility** OpenCTD build in small teams, led by Andrew Thaler Other builds and test deployments to be announced